

interviewer: So, before we start, how would you like us to refer to your partner during the interview?

interviewee: We can call him by his first name. So, it's [partner].

interviewer: [partner] OK. And how long have you been with [partner]?

interviewee: It'll be [6-10] years this year.

interviewer: [6-10] years, OK. To begin with, I'd like you to tell me a little about your history with [partner].

interviewee: Okay. OK. So, my meeting with [partner] was in [Year]. I was actually attending a professional meeting. In fact, I had just taken up a job and was invited as a witness to talk about my career path in front of young graduates, through [Company]. And so, as a result, I spoke at a networking evening and [partner] was one of the young graduates present and invited too. And that's when we met. It was an ordinary meeting, in fact, a professional one. I gave my little speech, my presentation. And at the end, there was time for questions and answers. Well, a time for questions. And so, he introduced himself to me as a young [occupation] with a recent degree. And that was that. There was no follow-up at the time. Then, a little later, he got back to me by e-mail, asking if we could meet outside a professional context. And that was it. So that's how it all started, our first meeting. It wasn't love at first sight, to be honest. It wasn't love at first sight at all. But it was an interesting encounter. And one thing led to another, and it's true that feelings got involved. And that's where the story was born, you could say, bearing in mind that I was married at the time. So I'd already been married for a few years. So I wasn't at all thinking of getting back together as a couple. But it all happened very gradually.

interviewer: Very gradual?

interviewee: Very gradually, in other words, it took us several months before we really... I can't remember the number of months, but it was definitely before we entered into a serious, ongoing relationship. [Redacted]. And we really became a couple, shall we say, the following year. Late [Year], early [Year].

interviewer: Right. And since then, since you've been together, how has it been?

interviewee: How has it been? I don't think we're an isolated case, but it's a relationship with a lot of ups and downs. It's a relationship that's been very unstable for a long time, also because it was born in a context that wasn't comfortable, as I was saying earlier, for either of us. Because I was the woman who cheated, and that's a label that sticks to you, whether you know it or not, but even the way I looked at myself wasn't necessarily very positive at the time. I mean, I wasn't proud of what I was doing. And it wasn't comfortable for him, because he had to keep it a secret, because he was single at the time. So it was a context, so to speak, of the emergence of a relationship that wasn't easy. And afterwards, it kind of... Unfortunately, I think it had a big influence on what happened next. Being... There you go. Because there's a bit of adrenalin at the beginning, there's this euphoria linked to the forbidden side of things, but afterwards, all that fades away, in fact. As soon as you become a more official couple, it all fades away, and you're back in a much more classic couple situation, and that's when we realized that the euphoria of the beginning is gone, and that's when things get a little more complicated. You learn to discover each other more, to discover each other's faults, and to discover facets of your own personality that you hadn't imagined either. And it's been... An up-and-down relationship, right up to the present day. It's been a bit of a rollercoaster ride, with a lot of instability, but with, I'd say, a very strong emotional underpinning. There really are feelings, there's affection, there's attachment, but with two characters, two very strong personalities, who sometimes find it hard to cohabit. But that didn't stop us from trying to live together, so we tried living together for the first time in [Year], which lasted a few months, because, once again, we were two individuals with rather imposing, rather dominant egos, so it only lasted a few months, and we ended up living separately between [Year] and until [Year]. We lived separately, but still maintained a relationship, and [Year], I got pregnant. So that's what forced us to go back to living under the same roof. So we had our first son in [Year], which transformed the relationship even further, and we had our second son in [Year]. So we're still under the same roof, and there are several of us now, four of us. That's all there is to it. So the relationship itself is very... It's always unstable, in fact, for me, that's the word that comes up a lot, it's that we have really very different characters, with very different world views, and sometimes we manage to complement each other, so that's what's quite amusing, shall we say. Sometimes we complement each other, and sometimes we're diametrically opposed. And that's why there are systematic variations in our relationship, because when we complement each other, everything's fine, and when we oppose each other, we inevitably get into a bit of a conflict. And so it goes. Except that today, as we also have a family, we have to be able to temper all that a little, and temper our equals a little, I'd say, and learn to live together. There you go.

interviewer: Yes, because you told me that it changed the relationship a lot, your first son, did it change him for the better?

interviewee: For better and for worse. Unfortunately, we weren't spared the baby-clash we weren't expecting. Parenthood is really about discovering yourself and discovering others. You discover yourself in a new role, and so it wasn't easy, especially for [partner] to find his place too. And I think, in many ways, I wasn't very helpful. I really didn't. I admit it, I wasn't helpful because I was the mother. I gave birth, I carried the child. And since all that happened in a context, let's say, where we

were in a phase of... Because in fact, I got pregnant at the beginning of [Year], but by the end of [Year], we were already talking about separation again. But this time, in a more definitive way. So all of a sudden, the pregnancy came on top of that, it wasn't planned. And so of course, once again, it didn't put us in the right frame of mind to have a harmonious and fulfilling relationship. So there you have it. So... So all of a sudden, we were already a bit fragile at the start of the pregnancy, and we were even more so when our first son was born, so with this story of everyone finding their place, everyone finding their feet, and then there's a child in the middle, who's alive and kicking, who's demanding, who's clamoring, who's got needs that we have to be able to meet, well, already, that we have to be able to identify in order to be able to meet them. It's been a long road, full of difficult, laborious and happy pitfalls.

We were interrupted.

interviewer: Yes, I'm sorry, my network must have been a bit unstable.

interviewee: Okay, no problem. No, so I hung up to call back. So, what I was saying was that... It was a first birth, but it didn't prevent a second one later, having a second child, where things are going better. Because, I think, there's experience from the first, there are lessons that have been learned, lessons that have been acquired, so I think that today it's helping us to get back on track a little and see things a little more serenely, I'd say. It's not a foregone conclusion, but we're a little more serene than when we had our first child, and a little closer than when we had our first. Hm. So that's it. So there you go. Oh yes, what I didn't mention earlier, in relation to the start of the story, is that I'm... Even though I separated from my husband at the time, well from my ex-husband, I didn't divorce him. I didn't divorce right away because it was too brutal. Even for me, in fact, it was... something I wasn't ready to do. I didn't feel ready to do it right away. So it's true that the fact of having stayed married also conditioned quite a bit the relationship I had with [partner], insofar as there was always this sort of illegitimacy of the couple's relationship, even though we were officially together. I still carried my ex-husband's name and I was still married. And I didn't get divorced until [Year]. I was only able to get divorced in [Year]. So there you go. So it's true that it doesn't help, I think. In any case, it didn't help the beginning of the relationship we had. There you go.

interviewer: So, you were married before. If you were to compare your relationship today with [partner] to the relationship you had before or other relationships you've had, what would you say?

interviewee: Well, I'd say they're [1-5] totally different relationships, but completely, really on every level. In other words, my ex-husband was quite taciturn, quite withdrawn, very composed, very quiet, very... very discreet, that's all. Very complex, too. And that's not at all the case with [partner], who's very open, very... how can I put it... very talkative. He's also very curious and well-educated. I think that plays a part. Very cultured. And it's true that... That's it. The comparison is quickly made:

today, I'm with someone with whom I have long, relevant, interesting conversations, whereas in my previous relationship, it was more like polite exchanges, but there was no conversation, no real plan for the couple either, no common project. I got married quite young, at [21-25], a bit by convention, because I came from a village where, in the end, it was a bit of a tradition. You end up getting married at some point, you end up having children, it's the order of things. And let's just say that I kind of followed the path that was already mapped out, and I didn't really ask myself any questions. So I married someone from my village. And it's really the fact of... That's it, because I'm not from [City] at all, I'm from another department, I'm from [City], and it's really the fact of having come to [Country] for training, in fact, that has already opened up the field of possibilities, that has opened up my mind, and that has enabled me to meet new people, and to see the world a little differently. And I think [partner] arrived just at the right moment, when I was also in this phase of discovery, and so he reinforced this idea I had, this desire I had to open up to the world, in fact, to get out of this small village mentality, where you really have to do things in order, get a job, study, get married, have children, buy a house, and that's it. And where social success carries a lot of weight, like a sword of Damocles hanging over your head, and if you don't succeed, you're quickly pigeonholed. And so, when I was finally able to leave my department to come and live in metropolitan France, so with my husband, at first, but still in this movement of openness, and finally, I met [partner] at that time, so for me, it was obvious, in fact, that it was logical. I said to myself, well yes, that's it, it's part of the evolution, it follows the path of evolution that I'm taking myself, and as a result, I couldn't go back, in fact. It was impossible for me to say to myself, ah bah no, you mustn't go too far, no, no, you must stay with your husband, you must have children. I couldn't do it anymore, I really wanted to be emancipated. And he helped me get there, so if there's one thing, yes, that I remember from our story, and for which I'm deeply grateful, it's that. It's the emancipation that he enabled, that he also initiated through his presence, through our relationship, that he enabled, and which today, I'm particularly proud of, because I think that if I had continued, in the end, on the same path, I wouldn't have been the same. I would have been much less open, less independent, and always with fixed ideas, which is not at all the case today. So, in terms of comparison... After that, my ex-husband had a lot of assets and a lot of qualities, because he was very patient, very helpful, solid, really very solid. And it's true that today, with [partner], at times, there are fragilities, so to speak. There are weaknesses and it's not... As a result, I have to compensate, and sometimes it's a bit wearing. In any case, that's how I feel. It's like a compensatory effect, saying that he can't do it, so I'm the one who can or I'm the one who has to. Especially now that I have a family, there's that side of things... If the partner can't, it's up to the mother, the wife, to carry the family. And that's not easy.

interviewer: And if you were to compare this relationship with [Name] with the one your friends have, your couples of friends?

interviewee: I'd say it's true that... For the few friends I have who are in a relationship, because there aren't necessarily many who are in a relationship, or in any case have been in a relationship for a long time, or are in a relationship on a regular basis, it's true that I feel we're not playing on the same field. I rarely compare myself to others, but it's true that I feel that yes, among friends who are

in a couple, at least there's something very stable. It's true, or at least it seems very stable. After that, I don't necessarily go into people's private lives, but from what I see, from what they let show, it's very settled, they're couples... One of them will finish the other's sentence. So it's very settled, there's a lot of apparent complicity, you can tell they know each other well. They're very established couples. And when I look at our relationship, which we've been in for [6-10] years anyway, with [1-5] children, I realize that we're still in a kind of instability, like a rocking boat, and we don't have that established side. We don't have that settled side, we still have that side where everything can change course from one day to the next. I think that's also due to the fact that, having thought about it for a long time and still thinking about it today, I think it's really due to the fact that I'm also trying to... How shall I put it? I'm still working on this idea of emancipation. In fact, I've stayed the course. I've kept the idea that I've emancipated myself from a village, a family, a husband, and today I'm really in this quest for individualism, to really refocus on myself. Which inevitably means that when you try to... It's not easy to find the balance between... Working on your individuality, so to speak, and being in a couple. It's a balance I'm still trying to find today. It's not always easy. I know they sometimes criticize me - we were talking about it just yesterday - for being very much in my own secret garden, for not necessarily wanting to share things, whether it's reading, hobbies or interests. And I tell her I need to. I need to keep that garden, to cultivate that secret garden, because I need to exist as a person before I can exist as a couple. And he's just the opposite. In any case, what he explained to me was that he needs to share, he's lonely, so he needs to share. And when he sees that he's trying to share with me and it's not working, or that I'm not receptive, or that I don't necessarily give the response he's expecting, he gets a bit upset. But not me. I don't share, and when I don't share, or when I do share, I don't necessarily expect the other person to tell me, whether or not they're interested in what I have to share. In the end, the result is the same for me. I'll carry on, I don't mind. So there you go. I think that's another reason why it's hard to establish anything today when your foundations are a little unstable.

interviewer: Would you say that you don't necessarily need the other person?

interviewee: Yes. It's true that what I tell myself is that the other person isn't indispensable to me. For me, today, it has to be a bonus. Being in a couple must be a bonus, it must be something... There has to be some added value. But if there isn't, in the end, it's not happiness. Maybe it's not... So, fortunately, we'll say that there are children too, there are bonuses elsewhere, in certain situations, but it's not... How can I put it? It's not permanent added value. There you go.

interviewer: You've told me about your two relationships, which are quite opposite in the end. For you, what defines a high-quality relationship?

interviewee: For me, a high-quality relationship is one where you communicate, where you communicate in a qualitative way, on a regular basis, even about the little things of everyday life. Not necessarily big issues, but little everyday things, and always maintaining a regular dialogue,

while also accepting each other's silences, obviously, because sometimes you don't feel like communicating, which is quite normal, but that's really the very basis, for me, which I didn't really have with my previous relationship, for example. So we communicated, but very sporadically, and then for things that were too non-essential, and as a result, there was no substance, there was no subject, there was no length in the conversations, so there you have it, for me, you have to find the right balance, have communication, so yes, on a day-to-day basis, I see that today, with [partner], we communicate on very philosophical subjects, on current affairs, on life projects, and that, on the other hand, speaking of added value, that, for me, is added value. And it's true that communication is the basis. And what else would define a quality relationship in my eyes? A form of loyalty. I know that... Well, I see it in relation to friends I've had, who've often confided in me or who've often made loyalty a strong value. I wouldn't call it fidelity, but I'd really call it loyalty, meaning that you have to be able to count on each other, that's all. We need to be able to stand together in difficult situations. We have to be able, and even more so when there are children involved, we have to be able to stick together, that's all, to face up to difficulties. And that, for me, is... In any case, for me, loyalty is a strong value. And it's true that it's something I expect and believe to be essential to a quality relationship. So there you have it. There's a certain sharing in communication. It's not just day-to-day communication, I mean. It's communication and loyalty.

interviewer: How do you recognize when you're in a relationship where there's loyalty and communication?

interviewee: Well, it's true that, in this case, if I take the relationship with [partner], it's by everything we do on a daily basis, by everything we can share. So, whether it's the conversations we have, that's something, because it's true that we talk a lot, well, when we have time, but in any case, when we do, we do it quite intensively. And above all, for example, when one or other of us is in difficulty, particularly in the case of my recent health problems, he looks after the children, he's there for them. It's these little things that mean there's not necessarily any need for big demonstrations, but in any case, it's these things that make me say that we're still communicating and we're still in a loyal relationship. There you go.

interviewer: Is there a moment in your relationship when you said to yourself, that you could say today, that was the most qualitative for you?

interviewee: The most qualitative? A period in our relationship? I'd say it was a lot... Despite the context, I'd still say it was the beginning, but then, that's a bit of an easy answer, because beginnings are always a bit of a fanfare. Yes, but it's true that the beginnings were particularly qualitative, despite the complicated context of the marital relationship I already had, because in the end, that's when, for me at least, he showed himself to be the most patient, the least demanding, which isn't the case today, and where I perhaps also showed myself to be the best listener, the most empathetic. As a result, it's true that this has an impact on our relationship. And

it's true that at that moment, we were in a construction where, in any case, I felt at ease, I felt valued, I felt loved, pampered, and really pushed to the wings, to tell myself that all that I had known before, of confinement, barriers, etc., suddenly, all that was gone. I became a freer, more independent, more open person. So it's for the reasons I was saying that he really contributed greatly to my emancipation, because all that, I think I had it inside me, it was very internalized, and then he helped to bring it to light. And so, by provoking these changes, yes, it was a bit... At the time, it was a little unsettling, but in the end, I can really see the progression between almost [6-10] years ago and today, but I'm not the same person at all, and I know, once again, deep down, that it's thanks to him. And I mustn't tell him too much, because if I do, his ego starts to swell. And that's it. So there you go.

interviewer: OK. And on the other hand, when would you say it was the least qualitative?

interviewee: The least qualitative, precisely, when there was this period of... This phase of... How should I put it? These phases of separation, because at that point, we were really on the verge of a precipice, we were on edge. I couldn't see myself, I said to myself, no, I'm not going to start all this work, all this personal change, only to end up in conflict with someone and living with someone who has put up with me. So it's true that he was both... ... How can I put it? He's someone who's carried me very high and at the same time has pushed me very low too, so it's really two extremes, in fact. That's it. ... Well, after that, there's always two of us. Well, I say him, but in fact, it's us. I'm not blaming him, but there you go. That's the main thing. That's what's been so difficult, to have had such high hopes and then to have seen those hopes dashed and to have fallen very, very far in a relationship that bordered on violence at times. I mean, psychological violence, with reproaches, with the exact opposite of what we'd set out to do. So there you have it. So it was really two extremes. It was I give you everything and I take it all back a hundredfold. So it's true that it really left its mark. I realize to this day that it left its mark. We're both wounded. We're like two wounded animals, each in our own corner. And we're trying to... Because afterwards, we also made choices and today, we're together and we have children. So today we've made the choice to try to repair things. But it's hard work. So that's that.

interviewer: And on the other hand, how would you describe a low-quality relationship?

interviewee: Well, low quality, I've been lucky, I've never had one, because for me, the few relationships I've had have all been qualitative in one way or another. Each in their own way. But I think that a low-quality relationship is precisely one where you have nothing to say to each other, where communication is non-existent, where, in the end, it's more a question of cohabitation than anything else. And I find that... For me, it's really... The older I get, the more I need to be able to share my partner to the extent that I give. In other words, not to contradict what I was saying earlier, I'm still cultivating a form of individualism, because I need it, it's really a fundamental need. So with this secret garden side, my interests, my own little garden, what I want to keep to myself. But at the

same time, I know that to have a quality relationship, you have to communicate, you have to keep exchanging. So necessarily, a low-quality relationship would be one where there's no communication. Or just day-to-day communication. Pass the salt... That's about it.

interviewer: OK. And apart from communication, loyalty, are there things that are very important to you in a loving relationship?

interviewee: Well, yes, there are things that are important, even essential, I'd say. In this case, the sexual relationship, intimacy, sharing each other's intimacy. So it can be in different ways. I don't necessarily see it as the sexual act, but sharing intimacy, sharing moments of complicity, for me, that's important. I think that's also... Because for a very long time, it's true that I'm not a very tactile person, generally speaking. Well, that's a family trait. But then, of course, when you're in a relationship, at least for me, it's important. It's important to rediscover that intimacy, not permanently, but regularly. It's always the same. I think it's through regularity that we can build things up, because to fall into a form of permanence would be to fall into a form of routine. And for me, routine doesn't always have a good side. It's reassuring on certain points, and a little more annoying on others. But on a regular basis, being able to get together and organize times can even be... There you go. And yes, the sexual relationship, well, the intimate relationship, I'd say, rather than the sexual one, in fact, for me, it's important that we can cultivate it. That's it. And also, in the same idea, it's about being able to continue to be seductive. I think it's important to be able to maintain a form of seduction towards the other person. But that doesn't necessarily mean dressing up every time and pulling out all the stops, but always being on the teasing side, in fact. I know I'm someone who likes a good laugh. Well, that can be a flaw, but it can also be a quality. But I know that I use my humor for that purpose, for the purpose of seduction. And well, it doesn't always work, but it's my way, in fact, of being on the slightly charming side, but at the same time, the slightly teasing side. And it's true that, for me, it's important to be able to continue to seduce the other person, to continue to please and above all to perceive, in the other person's eyes, that they still like you. And this, despite two pregnancies, despite a changing body, despite the inevitable ageing process, is something we don't always see. Unfortunately, we don't always see it. In any case, I know that I... I don't always live it very well, precisely because I say to myself, well, you don't have a choice, your body has changed, your skin has aged a little, but all of a sudden, I'd like to be able to continue to be perceived, in any case, as if it's... Without these elements being prohibitive, in fact. There you go.

interviewer: Which isn't always the case?

interviewee: Which isn't always the case, no, no. Sometimes, it's thrown back in my face that... I'm not the same. So that's... It's a shame. It's a shame. I'm not saying you have to live in denial or... Or... We always imagine the other person to be very beautiful, very desirable, very... But I'm simply saying that, in any case, my way of seeing things is that, for a relationship to last, you also have to

accept that the other person isn't the same as he or she was [6-10] or [16-20] years ago. You have to deal with a person who's evolving, in fact, who's changing, and accept these changes. And that's the only way we'll be able, with the acceptance of these changes, to really establish a long-term qualitative relationship. And... And... And unfortunately, sometimes, no, it doesn't work. So... So it's a pity, because I, on the other hand, or at least, I try to tell myself that the person lives, it's normal, the person can put on weight, it's normal, they can lose weight, it's fine, well... It doesn't matter, but at the end of the day, what matters is more than that. It goes beyond appearances. And this point of view isn't always shared. There you go.

interviewer: Based on what you've experienced with [partner], with your ex-husband, with your other relationships, what does love mean to you?

interviewee: So... Good question. Uh... Well... Love is... First of all, it's not easy to answer. It's... I'd link it to attachment, to affection. But let's just say... I'm discovering love mainly through my children these days. Because it's true that my parents weren't always... very... how should I put it... very demonstrative, or didn't always use a vocabulary that allowed us to feel that kind of love. So, today, I feel it through my children, and through my relationships. I mean, I wouldn't know how to define it. What I do know is that... Yes, there's certainly, very certainly been love in all the relationships I've had, love on both sides, but... But for all that, I couldn't really... put a definition on it. Let's just say it's pretty abstract for me.

interviewer: How do you feel about love through your children?

interviewee: Like an explosion. Like something... First of all, very demonstrative, because with children, it's true that it's a lot of hugs, a lot of kisses. Filial love, yes, it's... It's an explosion, it's full of positive energy, it's full of joy, and it's unconditional. It's really unconditional. Whether I'm on my good days or my bad days, my love for my children and my love for them remains the same. Unchanged. So I'd say that for me, love is synonymous with... How shall I put it? Consistency. That's it. A reference point. And... And of... Yes, of... Unconditionality. I don't know if the word exists, but surely. That would be it. That would be it.

interviewer: And how important is that to you in a relationship?

interviewee: Love?

interviewer: Yes.

interviewee: Uh... I think you need it, don't you? You need it to be able to... Uh... Yes, it takes love, and then... What can I say? Why does it matter? Well, you're giving me a hard time here! I think it's important, but I think what's really important is to have self-love. In other words, to be able to love others, you have to be able to love yourself a little. And it's above all this that needs to be worked on upstream, before even considering the relationship with the other person. First of all, you have to ask yourself how much you love yourself. How important is that? And then... And then, in the end, it's a bit of a prerequisite for me, so that afterwards, we can deploy this love towards others. And so, yes, it's... How important, I wouldn't know, but in any case, I know it's important, yes, of course, love, attachment in the relationship. Otherwise, there's no point in being two. You might as well be alone, I think.

interviewer: And how... You'd say you know [partner] loves you. How can you see that? What are the...

interviewee: Yeah... You'd have to ask him. Do you love me? Yes, I think he loves me. That's it, I think... in his own way. In his way, which may not be the way I need to be loved. That's it too. But in any case, in his way, yes. And I'd say... it's never in a blatant way or in a way... It's in the little things of everyday life. What I pointed out to him once was that in the morning, for example, when he prepared my coffee for me the night before, to make it easier for me... to save me time in the morning. He prepares it for me the night before. So for me, it's a gesture of love. When he wakes up and kisses me on the forehead. That's a gesture of love too. When he... When he does little things on a daily basis, for me, they're demonstrations of love that aren't necessarily big demonstrations, but at the same time, that's not the point. But I think that through these gestures, he shows me a form of love. And attachment. And attachment. Yes.

interviewer: We know that relationships can sometimes be complicated. Can you tell me about one of the last negative interactions you had with [partner]?

interviewee: Uh-huh. Yes. So it was... It was yesterday. It was just yesterday. We had a bit of a spat. But I'm trying to remember why. Yes, because I was telling him, in fact, about some thoughts or remarks he'd made to me at a time that wasn't very opportune. And that he had... He'd hurt my feelings. And so... And so, all of a sudden, he lost his temper. Right, because he really got carried away. He wasn't listening. And at the same time, maybe the way I brought things to him wasn't the right way either. So, once again, I'm not blaming him. It's not his fault or mine, but it's a context, it's a situation. So... There you go. What bothers me in these negative interactions is that the dialogue is quickly broken off in favor of an outburst, an emotion, anger, which prevents any communication. In other words... I know that I'm not always thinking clearly, because I have a very demanding job, I have a fairly heavy mental workload, and sometimes it takes me a while to get my

ideas straight and to be able to transcribe them clearly and coherently. So... When I get to a stage where I know I can express myself clearly, limpidly and coherently, I expect the feedback I get to be just as clear, limpid and coherent, and above all that it takes place in a rather serene and benevolent climate. However, as it was a question of picking up on thoughts that had been unpleasant for me, and sharing them with him, he didn't understand, got carried away and let his anger do the talking. His anger manifests itself by shouting, by raising his voice, by incessant verbal jousting, and it's true that, as a result, his anger inevitably fuels mine, and it's a dialogue of the deaf, with us shouting at each other, until one or the other gives in, or finally tires of the conversation, and that's what makes it so, afterwards, either we manage to find a way out and calm things down a bit and get back to a calmer conversation, or, in the end, we end up sulking on our own, until one or the other's anger subsides and we can get back to each other in a calmer way, but sometimes that takes time. So that's that.

interviewer: And the resolution of these spats takes time, in the end?

interviewee: It happens over time, when everyone takes a step back, when one or the other decides to acknowledge his or her faults, if I may put it that way, or at any rate to recognize that he or she has a responsibility or an impact in the situation. And it happens... So I do... Not often, but I take the initiative. Sometimes, I say to myself, well, come on, we've got to cut this short, we've got to bring a new breath, we've got to bring a new impetus. We can't afford not to talk to each other, we can't afford to be at each other's throats for [1-5] weeks. So, at some point, we have to defuse the situation. So sometimes I make the first move, but sometimes he makes the first move too. When he sees that in the end, well, maybe it wasn't worth getting so carried away. But sometimes, yes, it can take a few hours to a few days. And in the meantime, the atmosphere is very heavy, the climate is very heavy, the atmosphere is very heavy. And it's true that... You never really know how the situation will be resolved, or at any rate, what the outcome will be. Whether waiting will generate new anger, or whether, on the contrary, it will calm it down. So we're always on a bit of a filter, a bit tense. So, yeah, it's complicated.

interviewer: And these are just the little everyday spats? Are there bigger conflicts, bigger...?

interviewee: Yes, there are bigger ones over more important issues. I'm sorry about that. But this is the same. In fact, it's pretty much the same pattern. In other words, it's always anger that's going to come out. It's happened to me, though... Well, I manage to keep calm, but sometimes I explode. Sometimes I explode, and when I do, it's a bit of a whirlwind. Because, especially if it's something to do with... It's something that's particularly close to my heart, something that's particularly affecting me, so yes, it takes on different proportions.

interviewer: And what might these disputes be about?

interviewee: Decisions, for example, about our children that were made without my consent, for example. It could be personal choices. Typically, for example, yesterday's subject... Well, there were several subjects, but in this case, one of the subjects that came up was breastfeeding, because my last son is [6-10] months old, and I'm still breastfeeding him. So I feel that breastfeeding is already a personal choice. It's a project carried out by a couple, but one in which, ultimately, it's the mother who's very much involved, and the father accompanies her, in fact, he's there to reassure her. And it's true that I naturally made this choice for my first son, and I naturally made it for my second son, and it was a choice that was... In fact, we had a medical visit with the pediatrician yesterday, where she half-heartedly criticized this choice of breastfeeding, saying that that's it, he's [6-10] months old, it's okay, we can move on, and it's none of her business, in fact. And she doesn't have the right to tell me to wean my son or not wean my son, that's up to me. And I felt like... As if [partner] wasn't supportive, actually. He hadn't been either at times, but only occasionally. But in this case, for me, he hadn't been supportive either, telling me that if she wanted to breastfeed, she would, in fact. And so, that's a very intimate thing, it really touches on what characterizes me. In any case, it's part of my identity as a mother, and today, to see that this personal choice, which is certainly not easy to maintain, because my son is going to nursery school, and the nursery has a different way of working, and it's not always compatible with breastfeeding, to not feel supported, for me moreover, by the children's father, is really serious. It's quite a serious situation. And that, on the other hand, for me, creates a spat where you can be sure I'm going to be angry. So I had some unfortunate words, some nasty words, yesterday, when I got carried away, saying that... I quote, I quote myself, it's a bit vulgar, I'm sorry, but I said fuck you all, including you, to quote myself, and I said because that choice is mine. And as a woman, as a mother, I don't want it to be called into question, at any time, by anyone. Because today, we live in a society where, whatever we do, we're criticized. As social networks clearly show, everyone has an opinion on everything. We wear yellow socks, ah, but why did you wear yellow socks? You should have worn blue socks. Anyway. It's pretty frightening, so today, I can't imagine anyone criticizing breastfeeding, since it's a choice that's up to me and belongs to me and my son. So if I've decided to continue it, I'll continue it, and if I've decided to stop it, I'll stop it. It's this kind of strong theme, I'd say, that can create explosions, yes, in the couple, if the couple isn't in agreement, in coherence, on these subjects, for me, on the other hand, that can...

interviewer: Yes, personal issues...

interviewee: Personal matters, important matters, even essential matters, I'd say. As much as, there are subjects you can quickly move on to. Well, I know that, for example, once, [partner]... Well, I was angry that day, but afterwards, I said to myself, well, no harm done, my son was born with more or less long hair, and he took the initiative of cutting it himself, except that [partner] isn't a hairdresser. And so, all of a sudden, he did a crooked fringe, and for me, his hair is precious, and all of a sudden, I exploded. I exploded, because I said to him, what were you thinking cutting his hair? It's not right, you're not a hairdresser, it's crooked, it's ugly... Anyway, that's it, so I really got carried away. I was very angry with him, and I think it was the first time he'd ever been very angry,

but then I thought, well... Stepping back, taking a deep breath, I said to myself, well, that's okay, it's ugly, it bothers me, because he did it behind my back, but is it worth staying angry about? Hair grows back. So in the end, it went back down. So, on my own, I realized that my reaction was perhaps disproportionate, so I came back and said, well, that's it, we're moving on, and that's it, it's over.

interviewer: OK. What are the daily challenges you face in your relationship?

interviewee: Daily challenges... Apart from the challenges as parents, the challenge as a couple is to keep our relationship healthy, and that's a daily challenge. Healthy in the sense that, just the same, we have a relationship in which we can continue to communicate in a quality way, on a regular basis, and that's not always easy, because we're dependent on a daily life that's not easy, with [1-5] children, and in which we're not always available, in which we don't have much time. For me, my job and family life leave little or no time for anything else. And the little time I do manage to free up, well, that's the individualist talking and saying, well, I want to keep that little time for myself and not necessarily reinvest it in the couple. It's always that way. So, for me, keeping a healthy relationship, or at least building a balanced one, is the major challenge. And then, I'd also say, to keep in sight the why of this relationship too. Apart from the children, that's why we're in a relationship, why we're together, why we want to stay together, or why we stay together, and to be able to tell ourselves that it's not for comfort, but that there's something else, something that goes beyond comfort, and whether it's called love, attachment or something else, but in any case, something that binds us together. And it's true that even I tend to forget this. There are mornings when I say to myself, what am I doing as a couple? It doesn't make sense. And then there are moments when, oh yes, I remember. Memories are reactivated. For example, when I see him playing with the kids, when I see him doing something that's pleasant for me, not necessarily for me, but pleasant in general, when I see him making music.... I say to myself, that's what binds us together, that's what keeps us going... And it keeps us on course. And that's what keeps us going.

interviewer: And one of the last positive interactions you've had?

interviewee: One of the last positive interactions... So... Good question. It was earlier, actually. If I were to use that as an example, we had an appointment with a [occupation] for our eldest son, who's part of the nursery and who was able to observe our child, and who gave us very positive feedback. And so... So it's a silent interaction, for the moment, but it's the fact that we've exchanged a look of satisfaction, in fact. It's the fact that we've exchanged a look of satisfaction, in fact. So there's a little bit of pride, a little bit of... Our son is intelligent. And then, the fact that we can look at each other and say that, if our son is what he is, what we've done, what we've put into it, what we've done to educate him, to bring him up, and then, whether it's the father or the mother, but what we've been able to work on together to get him there, and that's always pleasant. So it was just an exchange of glances, a hug, but we say to each other that we're happy to be together and to

have succeeded together. Yes, I... It has a lot to do with the parents' relationship, in fact. It's true that... I realize, as I listen, that it's very much linked to the role of parent we have, but it's true that, as it's an everyday role we have today, so the couple relationship alone, and sometimes, it's hard to dissociate it from the parent couple.

interviewer: We've talked about conflicts, challenges and so on. I'd like to know what might make you leave [partner], today?

interviewee: So... What might make me leave him or what has made me not leave him yet? Sorry. I think that, despite our difficulties, we've still... Well, there's that attachment, there's the fact that we still manage to pull each other up. I hope, in any case, that I can pull him up. For my part, I think so. But I think that's what would make it possible for me to leave him, that at some point I'd realize that he was either making me stagnate, slowing me down or even sinking me, or that he was making me regress, that's all. I was looking for the word. That it makes me regress. In other words, as I was saying earlier, there's been a real emancipation phenomenon over the last [6-10] years or so. And I wouldn't go backwards for anything in the world. And if I had the impression today of falling back into similar patterns, with a form of... almost submissive to men, or if I realized that, well, at some point I'd revert to the role of woman, almost woman... Yes, submissive woman, in fact. Woman subject to man or father. I think that... In any case, I hope I'll have the reflex to leave soon. Well, that's that. Because for me, that would really be... That's what I ask for and what I claim most often, and he hears it, because as we have two more boys, so I'm in the minority, inevitably, I say that you respect me. You respect me in front of our children, so already, you respect me in our relationship, but you respect me in front of the children, and I want that when you address me, especially as a woman, that you don't talk to me like a dog. Anyway, I'll answer, that's for sure, I'll answer. Because I wouldn't have done it in the past, but now I'll answer. And if at some point I realize that I'm going backwards a bit, and that I'm showing a lack of respect, then yes, I could... It would certainly be a factor for me... An element, that's all, for leaving. That's it.

interviewer: OK. And would you say that this relationship is good for you?

interviewee: Good in what way?

interviewer: It's like you understand the question, like...

interviewee: Yeah. Is it good for me? Interviewer: Yeah. On certain points, yes. There you go. In some ways, yes. And in other ways, no. Clearly, no, insofar as this relationship has been very energy-consuming for as long as it's been going on. It's demanded a lot of... It's taken a lot of... In fact, it's stirred me up a lot, this relationship. So, even if... There you go. Let's just say that where it

brings me, where it's good for me, is that... That's the question too. Is it good for me at the moment? That's the question I ask myself. So, at the moment, I couldn't really say whether it's good or bad, if you had to take the two opposites. I'd say it's been good. That's what I'd say. She's been good, always in this role of trigger, in relation to her personal changes. She brought me balance, she brought me... She's given me renewal, she's given me a challenge, in short, she's given me a lot of things. Right now, I'm still thinking about it. And I can't make up my mind because, because at times, yes, and at times, no. At times, it harms me, or at times, it doesn't. I can't decide. At times, it harms me, or at any rate, I have the impression that it harms me, and at times, I have the impression that it supports me. But from one day to the next, it's so different that, in the end, I say to myself... I try to take it one day at a time and try to sort things out. There you go.

interviewer: We've already talked a lot about emancipation, etc., but do you think you've changed since the beginning of your relationship with [partner], for better or worse, what's changed for you personally?

interviewee: Yeah. Yes, I've definitely changed. For the better, precisely, in this idea of having become more independent, more enterprising, more proactive in many things, even on a professional level, in fact. In fact, let's say that [6-10] years ago, I could have settled for just a small job, that's all. Unpretentious, unambitious, because you had to work, you had to bring home a bit of money. I could have made do with, I'd say, short weekends, not necessarily long vacations, not necessarily wanting to travel and so on. So there you have it, these are just examples to show that in terms of openness, independence and taking the initiative, it's all led to some very positive changes. It really helped me evolve, mature and grow. What did it change for you? Well... It's made a lot of demands on me. I don't know if that's bad, but in any case, I know that today, I'm a bit more demanding in this relationship than I would have been a few years ago. I know that, as I was saying earlier, it has brought out sides in me that I hadn't imagined, but not necessarily always the right ones. I know that I have incisors in these words. In other words, when I'm going to make a reproach, I'm going to hit where it hurts, and I know it hurts, and I'm going to insist, because I'm sadistic, too. It's a figure of speech, but I know I can be very... I can be very mean in what I say. Even though I try to put it in the right way, sometimes it just comes out the way it comes out, and it's not nice to hear. And that's something I would never have dared to do before. I wasn't used to being mean. What's negative about it, too, is that... Well... Yes, no. I'd say no, that's the main thing, yes, that's it. It's the spicy side and then the nasty side. At times. Don't worry, I'm not normally mean. Because I work in the social sector, so if I start being mean...

interviewer: What do you do?

interviewee: I'm a [occupation]. So I have no interest in being mean. So there you go.

interviewer: OK. And as far as [partner] is concerned, has he changed between the beginning and today?

interviewee: Yes. It's normal for everyone to evolve in a relationship. So it's not even a reproach, it's not such a negative statement. But it's true that between the person at the beginning, who was full of enthusiasm, with a lot of patience too, a lot, a lot, a lot of empathy, a lot of empathy, but also a lot of benevolence towards me, who enjoyed listening to me when I spoke, it's true that with time, it's been diluted a little, it's been transformed. Sometimes when I tell an anecdote, it's true that I sometimes ramble, because memory makes us tell the same thing after a while, but I get remarks like "Yes, but you've already told me that, so you wouldn't want to move on to something else". When in fact, if I talk about it again, it's a memory that has touched me, that I'm keen to share. And even though I'm already working on myself to try and share a few things with him, when I do, I end up getting this feedback of "You've already told me" or "Yeah well, we're not going to spend three hours on it". So this lack of listening at times, when I'm feeling a bit vulnerable and want to share something, this lack of patience, at the start he was very patient, now he's much less so, a requirement that has also increased over the years on his part towards me, in particular, so that's very difficult to explain, well, it's very simple to explain, but it's difficult to talk about, for example on a physical level, when you have someone who loves you more or less unconditionally, who is all fire in the beginning and who after [1-5] or [6-10] years tells you "Ah, it would be good to go on a diet, it would be good to do some sport, it would be good to..." "There you go, so that's not nice to hear, it's the kind of comment we could do without and don't want to hear, even if it's true, there are some truths that are good to hear and others much less so, so we'd like to be appreciated for what we're worth, and that's why I was saying earlier that self-esteem is very important to me, and it's a good thing I'm able to appreciate myself just a little bit, because otherwise I think it does a lot of damage. So there you have it, her demands in relation to that have become almost a fixation, saying "it would be nice if you were more like this, more like that", but in fact my body belongs to me and I do what I want, if I feel like putting on 20 kilos, I put on 20 kilos. It's quite difficult to live with this changing outlook.

interviewer: Would you say you feel secure in this relationship?

interviewee: No, I wouldn't. Not 100%, anyway. On some points, yes, always the same, but on others, no.

interviewer: Would you like to tell me more?

interviewee: In terms of emotional security, yes. Then, in terms of classic security, yes. I'm not afraid of him. But no, because it's really always in line with what I was saying earlier, i.e. that there are too many inconstancies, there's too much instability, so there's always a moment when you say

to yourself “it's going to slip”, well, it's going to slip in the sense that it's going to break, in fact, it's going to fall apart, it's fragile. It's really the image of a house of cards, a house of cards that you're trying to build, you manage to lay the first solid foundations, and then you get the impression that as soon as there's a gust of wind, the whole thing could collapse. And that's really how I feel. So I'm a bit like the climate-anxious people who pack their suitcases or backpacks and leave them by the door. In other words, because I've seen it done by other people, who say that in the event of a nuclear explosion or whatever, you need to be able to get away quickly with the bare essentials, that's what I'm a bit like. Today, in this relationship, I've got my suitcase by the door and I tell myself I've got to be able to pick it up at any moment. Which isn't the way it should be, because it's unbearable to think that the relationship could end at any moment. But it's my way of protecting myself. It's my way of protecting myself and telling myself that if... I anticipate all the possible disappointments, all the umpteenth wounds that could occur, and I'm ready to go. And that's it.

interviewer: Yes, indeed, it's very energy-consuming, very...

interviewee: Yes.

interviewer: We talked earlier about sexuality, that it's an important part of a relationship. How important is it to you?

interviewee: For me, it's part of the relationship. It's an integral part of the relationship. It's something that, for me, is natural, for which I have no particular taboo. I don't have any... There you go. I think we should be able to talk about sexuality as a couple, but in a very open way and not just during sex. Because sometimes, some people are talkative and talk during the act and say things, but I think we should be able to express our desires, our fantasies quite openly, in fact, and say what we like, what we like less, what we want. So, if only, once again, in terms of communicating about sexuality, I think we need to be fairly transparent. And then, in terms of the intimate relationship, whatever form it takes, you need to be able to have these times of intimacy on a regular basis. Regularly. For me, it's something that can't be quantified. I wouldn't say you have to make love once a week, twice a week, because that doesn't make sense to me. It's not a question of quantity, it's a question of quality, the quality of the relationship, and the moments we can give each other, the moments when we can indulge each other, and for me, that's an integral part of the relationship. If there isn't that, for me, the relationship as a couple, in fact... So I understand that there are asexual people, I think it's called, who don't have sex and are quite happy with it, and so much the better, but for me, no, for me, it's part of it. And that's it. Because I associate it with the notion of pleasure, the notion of sharing, the notion of intimacy, and for me, it's all really part of... It's what ultimately consolidates the couple. Without that, it's complicated.

interviewer: And even if it's not quantifiable, how often do you have intercourse at the moment?

interviewee: So... At the moment, it can range from 1... So really, right now, just recently, because I gave birth last year, it took a while, but right now, I'd say once or twice a week, yes. That's it.

interviewer: And would you say you're satisfied with your sex life today?

interviewee: It could be better. It can be better, but even for me, in fact. It's true that this was one of the topics of conversation we had recently, where I feel that yes... Afterwards, when I've maybe lost the pregnancy weight, I'll feel better, but in any case, yes, it's not total satisfaction, it's not total pleasure, but we're getting there. I think that in this case, there's also the particular context of a pregnancy that's not very far off, which means that libido takes a long time to return post-partum, which isn't easy. There's also fatigue, lack of sleep and lack of availability. But in any case, I can see that we've resumed relations and that it's a pleasure to be together again. It's the pleasure of getting together, the pleasure of doing something together, and then... But it's true that there are still areas for improvement.

interviewer: Well, as far as the interview is concerned, it's fine with me. I've just got some little scales, if you don't mind. So... I have a problem sharing my screen, so if it's okay with you, I'll read them to you. Is that okay with you? So, from 1, which is not at all true, to 9, which is completely true, how would you rate the degree to which, in general, my partner really listens to me?

interviewee: 6

interviewer: 6, OK. Why 6?

interviewee: Why 6? Because... How can I put it? Namely that 1, it's not true at all, and 10, it's totally true. 6, because I feel that, yes, he listens to me and listens to me, but it's very random. It's very random, so... And as he's having a little trouble memorizing at the moment, so... So, I don't know if it's linked to the memorization problem or to the fact that he doesn't listen to me, but in any case, I don't always feel listened to.

interviewer: Then we have a second question, always from 1 not at all true to 9 completely true. Is my partner generally attentive to my needs?

interviewee: 6 too.

interviewer: 6, OK.

interviewee: Yeah.

interviewer: Why?

interviewee: Because, very often, he's attentive to his needs, which he'll... which he'll, how can I put it, not pass on to me, but how can I put it, for which he'll associate me, even though they're not my needs, they're his. So he's going to think that I have the same needs as he does, when that's not the case at all. That's what I blame him for, by the way.

interviewer: Right. Um... De... How satisfied are you with your relationship? Well, it's not going to be numbers, it's going to be completely dissatisfied, very dissatisfied, rather dissatisfied, neutral, rather satisfied, very satisfied or completely satisfied.

interviewee: So satisfaction with the relationship.

interviewer: Yes, the relationship.

interviewee: Neutral.

interviewer: Neutral, OK. And then, from “-10 to 10”, so “-10”, completely dissatisfied, “-0”, not at all...

interviewee: Still on the same question?

interviewer: Yes, uh... Yes, your degree of satisfaction, from “-10 to 10”, 10 completely satisfied and -10 completely dissatisfied.

interviewee: Uh... Satisfaction... Er... Okay, same thing, let's cut the door in half and say 5.

interviewer: -5... So this is a scale that goes all the way to the negative, to “-10”. In the middle, it's 0. Then...

interviewer: Right. Let's say 2, then.”

interviewer: 2, OK.

interviewee: Yeah, it's not quite half, but...

interviewer: In the positive, though?

interviewee: Yes, in the positive, anyway, yes. There are worse relationships, I think.